

Trade diplomacy: on India-Bangladesh trade-related tensions

Trade **restrictions** against Bangladesh **will** not have much **coercive** value

In an **escalation** of **bilateral** trade-related tensions, India recently announced restrictions on readymade garments and other specified commodities from Bangladesh. The Directorate General of Foreign Trade's **announcement** targeting Bangladesh's **vital apparel** sector **sent** an unmistakable signal that **deteriorating** political relations have now **spilled over** into economic **ties**. By specifically denying Bangladeshi goods access to India's northeast market, New Delhi has delivered a **pointed** message to Mohammed Yunus, Bangladesh's interim leader, who during his visit to China in March 2025 had invited Chinese access to India's northeast through Bangladesh, describing the northeast as **landlocked**. While India's **discomfiture** about Bangladesh-China discussions regarding India's northeast **is** understandable, this trade restriction may hurt Bangladeshi businesses, largely dependent on garment export, but will do little to **aid** New Delhi's strategic interests. Bangladesh's recent political **turmoil stems from** protests against its former elected government, and the **interim leadership** — struggling with **resistant bureaucracy** and ongoing instability — **has** blamed New Delhi due to its **perceived** close ties with the previous administration led by Sheikh Hasina. The Yunus-led administration's **warming up** to Pakistan, and its **ban** on the Awami League — actions that go against its promises to the international community — **have worsened** relations. The **imperative** for New Delhi must be to come up with a **deft outreach** to other political parties in Bangladesh as they prepare for elections. While Mr. Yunus had announced that elections will be held later this year, there is still no clarity on the date.

New Delhi must, **in consonance with** the rest of the international community, advise the **regime** to conduct elections quickly. A political **gesture** of this nature while engaging with multiple **stakeholders** in Bangladesh's polity **is** more appropriate than using restrictive moves related to trade, as this would only **heighten** the anti-India sentiment being **fanned** by some elements in Bangladesh after the Awami League government's exit. Such **radical elements**, many of whom have little investment in the **restoration** of democratic processes, **could** also create fresh law and order problems that could lead to security issues in the northeast. India should carefully **lay out** its response **keeping in mind** that while it has to communicate its **displeasure** to the Yunus government, it also has to maintain working relations with this administration till a popularly elected government takes charge in Dhaka.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

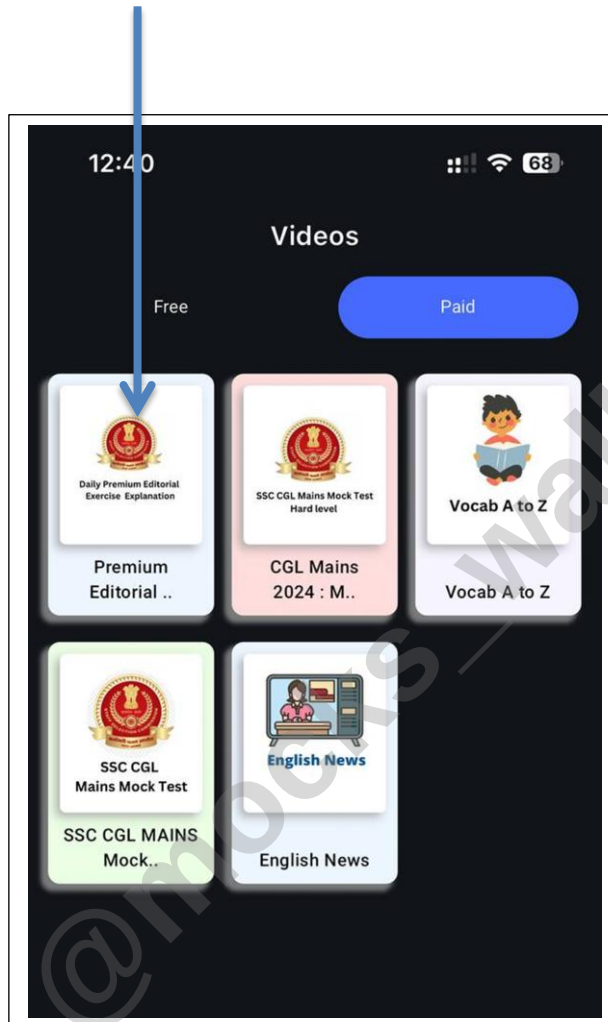
[Practice Exercise]

Vocabulary

1. **Diplomacy** (noun) – negotiation, international relations, tact, foreign affairs, statesmanship कूटनीति
2. **Coercive** (adjective) – forceful, intimidating, threatening, repressive, compelling बलपूर्वक / दबाव बनाने वाला
3. **Escalation** (noun) – intensification, increase, amplification, surge, aggravation वृद्धि / तेज़ी
4. **Bilateral** (adjective) – mutual, two-sided, reciprocal, joint, shared द्विपक्षीय
5. **Vital** (adjective) – essential, crucial, necessary, important, indispensable महत्वपूर्ण
6. **Apparel** (noun) – clothing, garments, attire, outfit, wear वस्त्र / परिधान
7. **Deteriorate** (verb) – worsen, decline, degrade, crumble, weaken बिगड़ना / गिरावट आना
8. **Spill over** (phrasal verb) – spread, extend, overflow, diffuse, cross over फैल जाना
9. **Ties** (noun) – connections, relations, bonds, links, associations संबंध
10. **Pointed** (adjective) – sharp, direct, explicit, clear, specific स्पष्ट
11. **Landlocked** (adjective) – inland, enclosed, surrounded by land, without sea access, cut off घिरा हुआ
12. **Discomfiture** (noun) – embarrassment, unease, discomfort, awkwardness, distress असहजता / परेशानी
13. **Aid** (verb) – help, assist, support, facilitate, benefit – सहायता करना
14. **Turmoil** (noun) – chaos, unrest, disorder, upheaval, agitation – उथल-पुथल / अशांति
15. **Stem from** (phrasal verb) – originate from, arise from, result from, come from, be caused by से उत्पन्न होना
16. **Interim** (adjective) – temporary, provisional, acting, transitional, short-term अस्थायी
17. **Resistant** (adjective) – opposing, defiant, unyielding, reluctant, uncooperative विरोधी / प्रतिरोधी
18. **Bureaucracy** (noun) – administration, red tape, officialdom, government machinery, civil service नौकरशाही
19. **Perceived** (adjective) – supposed, apparent, believed, assumed, seen as समझा गया / माने गए
20. **Warming up** (noun) – improving ties, getting closer, friendly approach, rapprochement संबंधों में सुधार

21. **Worsen** (verb) – deteriorate, aggravate, decline, intensify, degrade और बिगाड़ना
22. **Imperative** (noun) – necessity, priority, obligation, requirement, essential अत्यावश्यक कार्य
23. **Deft** (adjective) – skillful, tactful, nimble, agile, clever कुशल
24. **Outreach** (noun) – engagement, connection, communication, extension, contact संपर्क / पहल
25. **In consonance with** (phrase) – in agreement with, in harmony with, in alignment with, consistent with, matching के अनुरूप
26. **Regime** (noun) – government, administration, authority, leadership, ruling system व्यवस्था
27. **Gesture** (noun) – sign, act, indication, signal, expression संकेत
28. **Stakeholder** (noun) – party involved, participant, contributor, partner, entity हितधारक
29. **Heighten** (verb) – intensify, increase, escalate, amplify, enhance बढ़ाना
30. **Fan** (verb) – incite, provoke, stir up, fuel, spread भड़काना / हवा देना
31. **Radical** (adjective) – extreme, revolutionary, militant, drastic, fundamentalist उग्र / कट्टर
32. **Restoration** (noun) – reinstatement, revival, return, reestablishment, renewal पुनःस्थापना
33. **Lay out** (phrasal verb) – present, explain, outline, detail, define प्रस्तुत करना
34. **Keep in mind** (phrase) – consider, remember, take into account, be mindful of, bear in mind ध्यान में रखना
35. **Displeasure** (noun) – dissatisfaction, discontent, annoyance, resentment, irritation असंतोष

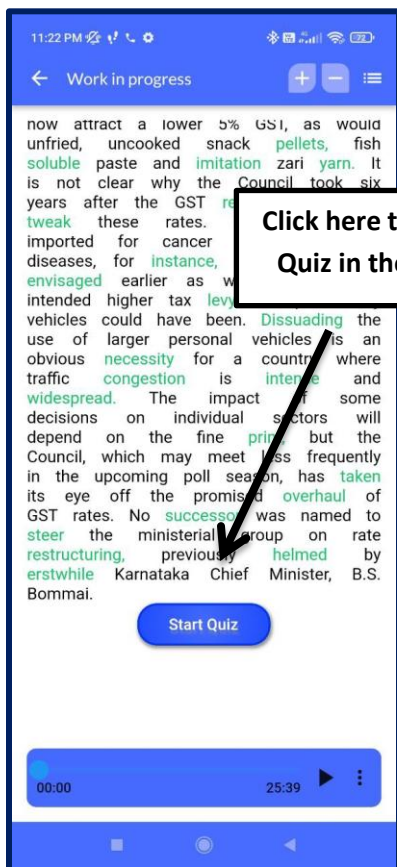
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Summary of the Editorial

1. India has imposed trade restrictions on readymade garments and other goods from Bangladesh.
2. These restrictions are seen as a response to deteriorating political ties between the two countries.
3. Bangladesh's garment industry, a major export sector, is likely to be economically affected by these measures.
4. The restrictions specifically target Bangladeshi access to India's northeast market.
5. This move appears to be a reaction to Bangladeshi interim leader Mohammed Yunus inviting China to access India's northeast via Bangladesh.
6. Yunus had described India's northeast as landlocked during his March 2025 visit to China, raising Indian concerns.
7. India's trade move is aimed at expressing political disapproval rather than achieving strategic outcomes.
8. Bangladesh's political instability, especially the ouster of the Awami League and rising protests, has fueled tensions.
9. The interim Yunus government has blamed India for allegedly supporting the previous Sheikh Hasina administration.
10. Yunus's tilt towards Pakistan and ban on the Awami League have further strained ties and broken promises to the global community.
11. India must shift from coercive trade tactics to political engagement with multiple parties in Bangladesh.
12. Pressuring Bangladesh diplomatically to hold timely elections is more constructive than economic sanctions.
13. Trade restrictions could worsen anti-India sentiment already growing within Bangladesh.
14. Rising hostility could destabilize India's northeast if radical elements exploit tensions for law-and-order disruption.
15. India should balance expressing displeasure with maintaining practical relations until a democratic government is elected in Dhaka.

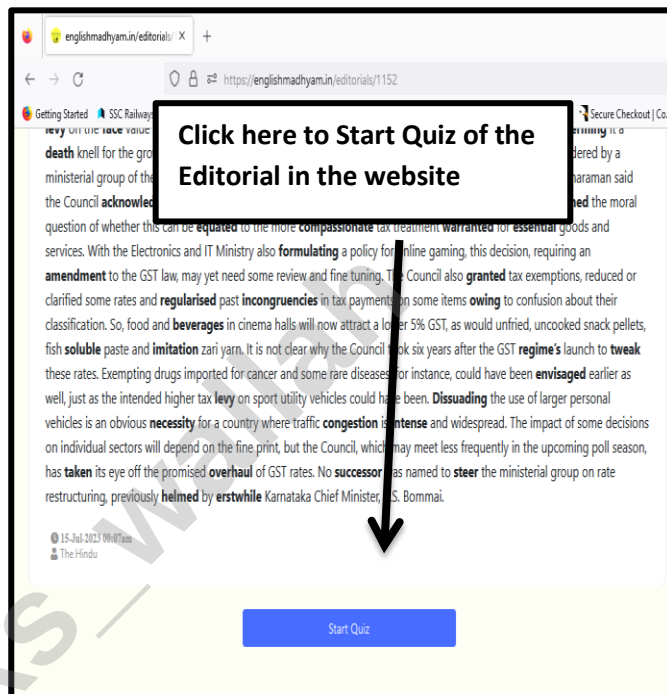
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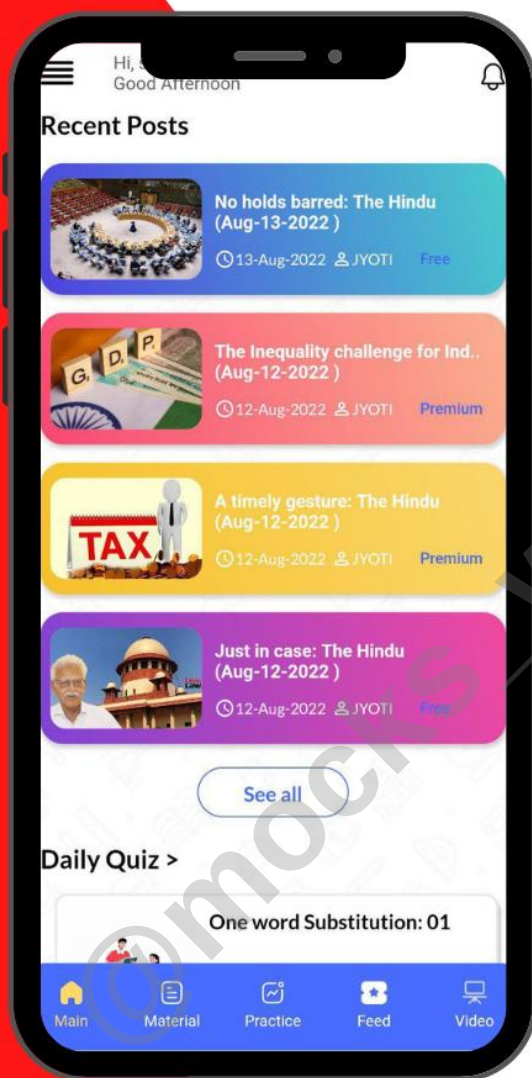
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